Digital Library Perspectives

Mnemonic infrastructures and the preservation of literary memory: institutional approaches to digital archiving in India

Vibha
Birla Institute of Technology and Science Pilani, Pilani Campus, Pilani, India, and

Sushila Shekhawat
Department of Humanities and Social Sciences,
Birla Institute of Technology and Science Pilani – Pilani Campus, Pilani, India

Received 24 April 2026
Revised 25 May 2026
Accepted 25 May 2026

Abstract

Purpose – This paper aims to examine how archival and cultural institutions in India organize the preservation of literary materials within emerging digital infrastructures. Drawing on insights from memory studies, archival theory and digital media studies, the study conceptualizes these institutions as mnemonic infrastructures that shape how literary memory becomes visible, legitimate and retrievable within digitally mediated environments. The research investigates how institutional mandates influence the preservation of print heritage, electronic literature and other forms of literary expression within digital repositories.

Design/methodology/approach – The study adopts a qualitative and comparative research design combining thematic analysis and qualitative content analysis. Data were collected between 2024 and 2025 through three phases of semi-structured interviews and institutional document analysis involving stakeholders from the National Archives of India, Sahitya Akademi, the Indira Gandhi National Center for the Arts, the Central Institute of Indian Languages and related digital initiatives. Institutional mission statements, policy documents and repository frameworks were analyzed to examine how archival vocabularies, mandates and technological infrastructures shape digital preservation practices.

Findings – The findings indicate that institutional approaches to digital preservation remain strongly influenced by print-based archival traditions. Most initiatives prioritize the digitization of print literary materials, while born-digital literary forms such as electronic literature remain underrepresented in institutional repositories. Institutional mandates also shape how literary memory is framed, with archival agencies emphasizing historical documentation and cultural identity.

Originality/value – The paper contributes to digital library research by offering a comparative institutional framework for understanding how literary memory is organized within digital preservation initiatives.

Keywords Digital preservation, Digital libraries, Archiving, Literary memory, Electronic literature, India

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

The study of digital archiving sits at the intersection of memory studies, archival theory and digital media scholarship, and it is characterized by an ongoing debate about whether digital technologies fundamentally transform collective memory or merely extend earlier archival logics (Bar-Gil, 2025; Edy and Austin, 2022). Some scholars interpret the rise of digital infrastructures as a rupture that produces entirely new forms of memory organization (Bar-Gil, 2025; Black, 2024; Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020), while others emphasize continuity between digital and pre-digital archival practices (Edy and Austin, 2022; Herremans, 2026; Verschure and

Digital Library Perspectives
© Emerald Publishing Limited
2059-5816
DOI 10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

Wierenga, 2022). Within this debate, Mandolessi advances a critical intermediary position. Rather than framing digital archives as a completely new cultural formation, she argues that digital memory practices materialize theoretical insights that memory studies had articulated from its inception: that collective memory is always a process mediated through technologies, institutions and communities (Mandolessi, 2023). What changes with digital media, therefore, is not the fundamental nature of memory but the infrastructural conditions through which it operates.

Mandolessi identifies several transformations that accompany this infrastructural shift. Digital environments introduce a new ontology of the archive in which materials exist within networked infrastructures rather than bounded institutional repositories. Agency becomes distributed across human and non-human actors, including algorithms, metadata schemas and platform architectures. Moreover, the stable mnemonic object that traditionally structured archival thought gives way to what she terms mnemonic assemblages that refers to configurations in which people, artifacts, technologies and practices interact within dynamic relational networks (Mandolessi, 2023). Memory in digital contexts therefore emerges less as a static record of the past and more as an evolving process mediated through technological infrastructures and social participation.

While Mandolessi's framework clarifies the conceptual foundations of digital memory, other scholars extend this analysis by examining how these transformations unfold within contemporary media environments. Digital infrastructures redistribute archival agency by enabling the self-organization of audiences and communities in the production of cultural memory (Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020). In such environments, the boundary between institutional archives and participatory collections becomes increasingly porous. Digital users do not simply access archival materials but contribute to their circulation, description and contextualization. Archiving therefore becomes a decentralized cultural practice rather than a function monopolized by professional institutions (Bar-Gil, 2025). In this sense, Mandolessi's theoretical account of distributed agency finds its sociological expression in the participatory dynamics of digital media ecosystems.

Scholars of digital memory and archival studies have further argued that the archive should be understood not merely as a storage site but as a dynamic socio-technical system through which cultural knowledge is organized and interpreted (Bar-Gil, 2025; Edy and Austin, 2022). This field is characterized by a central debate between scholars who view digital infrastructures as a fundamental rupture creating new forms of memory and those who view them as an extension of long-standing archival logics (Bar-Gil, 2025; Black, 2024). One influential framework emerging from this literature is John Hartley's concept of the probability archive (qtd in Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020). Traditional archival systems operate on the assumption that carefully curated collections managed by experts can provide authoritative and comprehensive representations of the past. In contrast, probability archives function within large digital informational environments where retrieval depends less on curatorial completeness than on the likelihood that relevant materials can be discovered through search algorithms, metadata relations and networked data sets. Rather than guaranteeing the presence of particular historical records, digital archives increase the probability that relevant artifacts can be located within vast informational networks.

This shift reflects broader transformations in digital archival environments. Digital media infrastructures facilitate the decentralization of archival functions, enabling users to participate actively in the creation, description and circulation of cultural memory (Black, 2024; Herremans, 2026; Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020). In networked environments, archives increasingly emerge through collaborative practices such as tagging, editing, hyperlinking and content sharing (Edy and Austin, 2022). The boundaries between institutional archives

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

and participatory collections therefore become increasingly porous. Memory production no longer occurs exclusively within professional archival institutions but also within distributed networks of digital users.

The epistemological implications of this transformation are significant. In traditional institutional archives, experts select and classify materials according to disciplinary knowledge systems, thereby providing users with a sense of certainty regarding the authenticity and context of archival records. In decentralized digital environments, however, archival authority becomes less stable. Users can search, reinterpret and redistribute archival objects across multiple platforms, often detaching them from their original institutional contexts (Bar-Gil, 2025). Meaning is therefore not fixed within archival objects themselves but emerges through dynamic patterns of interpretation, circulation and recombination (Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020).

These decentralized archival systems have been described as dynarchives, cybernetic systems characterized by permanent reconfigurability in which memory functions as an ongoing communicative process rather than a fixed cultural record (Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020). Within such environments, archives operate as sites of cultural dialogue rather than static repositories of historical evidence. The archive becomes a space where cultural meanings are continuously negotiated through interactions between users, platforms and technological infrastructures.

Digital platforms also enable the emergence of informal archives and heritage initiatives from ground up approach, allowing marginalized communities to construct alternative narratives that challenge dominant historical accounts. Herremans (2026) described how communities use digital tools as part of an archival imagination, assembling fragments of historical evidence to reconstruct suppressed histories and assert their right to narrate. Similarly, Black (2024) demonstrated how autonomous heritage groups mobilize archival fragments and personal memories to preserve small heritages that exist outside state-sponsored narratives of national history. These initiatives highlight the democratizing potential of digital archival environments by expanding the range of voices that can participate in memory production.

However, the expansion of digital archives is accompanied by a structural paradox that complicates narratives of archival democratization. Wendy Chun conceptualizes this paradox as enduring ephemerality, referring to the simultaneous permanence and instability of digital information (Chun 2008, cited in Mandolessi, 2023). Digital materials appear infinitely preservable because they can be endlessly reproduced and circulated across digital networks. Yet they remain dependent on technological infrastructures such as hardware systems, software platforms and file formats, that are themselves unstable and subject to rapid obsolescence. Digital preservation is therefore both technologically enabled and structurally uncertain.

This instability redistributes archival responsibility beyond professional institutions. Individuals increasingly contribute to systems of cultural memory through personal digital archives such as emails, photographs, social media posts and creative works. These personal collections hold both self-value, serving as resources for identity construction and social value, contributing to broader processes of collective memory formation. As institutional archives struggle to guarantee the long-term stability of digital materials, everyday digital practices increasingly supplement formal archival infrastructures.

Recent research on digital memory further emphasizes the role of connective memory, which emerges through continuous interactions between people, media and technological systems (Bar-Gil, 2025). In such environments, personal memories become linked across multiple platforms and data sets, enabling fragmented records to be assembled into broader

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

narratives of collective remembrance. Bar-Gil illustrates this process through the case of Hanna Kugler's wartime notebook, which evolved from a private document into part of a transnational digital memory network. Initially discovered as a handwritten Yiddish note known as a *tsetalleh*, hidden within a notebook containing everyday records, the document prompted Kugler's family to investigate her survival story during the Holocaust.

Institutional archives later provided additional records documenting her experiences. At Yad Vashem, a "Page of Testimony" detailing the deaths of Kugler's family members was discovered among archival records originally collected for commemorative purposes in the mid-twentieth century. The digitization of these archives in the early 2000s enabled multiple testimonies provided by Kugler over several decades to be accessed simultaneously within a searchable database. Technologies such as optical character recognition (OCR) and volunteer indexing further allowed fragmented testimonies to be merged into a unified digital profile, effectively collapsing chronological separation by presenting dispersed records within a single searchable interface (Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020; Bar-Gil, 2025).

Digital platforms further expanded this archival reconstruction. Through search engines, AI-assisted translation and collaborative platforms such as Wikipedia, previously unknown records such as a Russian archival document listing murder victims from Kugler's hometown, were discovered and incorporated into the narrative of her survival. Online communities participated in the verification and contextualization of these materials through processes of consensual validation, linking personal testimony with institutional documents, photographs and historical debates. Through these networked processes, Kugler's private notebook became part of a broader system of connective memory, demonstrating how digital infrastructures transform personal records into elements of global collective memory.

These theoretical perspectives conceptualize the digital archive as a socio-technical assemblage shaped by institutional authority (Bar-Gil, 2025; Edy and Austin, 2022), participatory cultural practices (Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020), algorithmic infrastructures (Herremans, 2026) and structural ephemerality (Verschure and Wierenga, 2022). Archives are no longer stable repositories but dynamic environments in which multiple actors negotiate the preservation, circulation and interpretation of cultural materials. Institutional archives remain important nodes within this system, yet they coexist with decentralized archival practices emerging across digital networks.

Despite the growing sophistication of this scholarship, an important gap remains. Much of the existing literature focuses either on the theoretical transformation of archives in the digital era (Black, 2024; Verschure and Wierenga, 2022) or on participatory digital memory practices within global digital platforms (Bar-Gil, 2025; Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020). Far less attention has been given to how these transformations interact with existing institutional archival infrastructures, particularly in multilingual and postcolonial contexts where state cultural institutions continue to play a central role in shaping national cultural memory.

This study addresses that gap by examining how multiple archival regimes operate simultaneously within the Indian cultural landscape. Rather than assuming a singular model of digital preservation, it investigates how documentary, canonical, linguistic, database-driven, audiovisual and intermedial archival infrastructures organize literary memory in different ways. By situating these institutional practices within the broader theoretical debates outlined above, the study demonstrates how archives actively shape the conditions under which literature survives, circulates and becomes part of collective cultural memory in the digital age.

2. Data collection and methodology

This study adopts a qualitative and interpretive research design to examine how archival institutions in India conceptualize and implement digital preservation in relation to literary memory. Rather than evaluating digital repositories solely as technical infrastructures, the

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

research focuses on how institutional mandates, archival vocabularies and preservation practices shape the definition and preservation of the literary object within contemporary archival environments. The methodological approach is informed by a theoretical framework that integrates insights from memory studies, archival theory and digital media studies. Within this framework, archives are conceptualized as mnemonic infrastructures, institutional arrangements that shape how cultural materials become visible, legitimate and retrievable within collective memory. This perspective allows the study to investigate how archival institutions not only preserve literary heritage but also actively participate in defining what literature is, how it should be preserved and how it becomes part of public knowledge in digitally mediated environments.

Data for the study were collected between 2024 and 2025 through three phases of qualitative data collection, combining institutional document analysis with stakeholder interviews across the archival institutions examined in this study. The first phase focused on gathering publicly available institutional materials, including mission statements, mandates, policy documents and digital repository descriptions. These materials provided insight into how each institution defines its preservation priorities and articulates its role in safeguarding cultural and literary heritage. The second phase involved the analysis of institutional communication materials and archival documentation, including descriptions of digitization initiatives, metadata frameworks and digital preservation strategies used by different institutions. This phase enabled a preliminary mapping of how archival infrastructures organize access to literary materials and how institutions distinguish between digitization practices and digital preservation initiatives.

The third phase of data collection consisted of semi-structured interviews conducted with officials and stakeholders from the institutions examined in this study. Interviews were conducted across multiple rounds during 2024 and 2025 and involved representatives from the National Archives of India (NAI), Sahitya Akademi, the Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL), the National Digital Library of India (NDLI), the Archives and Research Center for Ethnomusicology and the Indira Gandhi National Center for the Arts. These interviews explored institutional perceptions of digital preservation, the perceived relationship between print heritage and digital archiving and the challenges posed by technological obsolescence and evolving archival infrastructures. Interview participants were also asked to reflect on how their institutions define the literary object within archival systems and how digital initiatives influence decisions regarding what forms of literary expression are preserved.

The collected data were analyzed using thematic analysis and qualitative content analysis. Thematic analysis was used to identify recurring conceptual patterns in institutional discourse related to digital preservation and literary archiving. Particular attention was given to themes such as the definition of the literary object, institutional attitudes toward print and born-digital materials and perceptions of technological change in archival environments. Content analysis was used to examine how institutions use specific archival vocabularies when describing their preservation practices. By comparing the language used in institutional documents and interviews, the study analyzes how different organizations conceptualize literary materials and how these conceptualizations influence archival decision-making.

A central analytical focus of the study was the distinction between digitization and digital preservation. Digitization refers to the conversion of existing print-based materials into digital formats, while digital preservation refers to the safeguarding of born-digital materials and digital-native cultural forms. Examining how institutions interpret and prioritize these

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

two processes provides insight into how archival infrastructures respond to the challenges of preserving literary culture in the digital era.

The study adopts a comparative institutional approach to examine how different archival organizations structure literary memory through their preservation practices. By comparing institutions with distinct mandates, including national archives, literary academies, linguistic preservation institutes, digital knowledge platforms and audiovisual archives, the research identifies how different archival regimes produce different forms of literary memory. This comparative perspective reveals how institutional priorities, technological infrastructures and legal mandates shape the ways in which literature is preserved, accessed and interpreted.

Through this methodological approach, the study demonstrates that digital preservation practices cannot be understood solely as technical processes. Instead, they are embedded within institutional frameworks that influence what materials are preserved, how they are classified and how they become accessible within public knowledge systems. By examining these processes across multiple institutions, the study highlights how archival infrastructures participate in redefining the literary object and reshaping literary memory within contemporary digital environments.

3. Findings and discussion

This study finds that archival institutions in India do not simply preserve literary heritage that already exists. Rather, they shape the conditions through which literary memory becomes visible, legitimate and retrievable. Interpreted through recent work in memory studies and archival theory, these institutions can be understood as mnemonic infrastructures including assemblages of legal frameworks, institutional mandates, preservation technologies, metadata standards, digital interfaces and cultural narratives that collectively structure how the past enters public knowledge (Şerban, 2024, 5–7). Their relevance for literary analysis therefore lies not only in the materials they preserve but also in the mechanisms through which literature becomes archivable and publicly accessible.

From this perspective, the archive functions as a mediating structure that translates literature into multiple institutional forms, including documentary record, canonical heritage, linguistic resource, searchable metadata object, audiovisual performance trace or intermedial cultural assemblage. These transformations suggest that literary memory is not a fixed entity awaiting preservation but a socially organized process shaped by institutional practices, technological infrastructures and cultural priorities. At the same time, the findings indicate that this process is selective. Different institutional configurations prioritize particular forms of literary expression which are often those that are written, formally recognized or institutionally validated, while other forms remain less visible within archival systems. The following sections therefore examine each institution as a distinct configuration of mnemonic infrastructure, considering both the forms of literary memory they enable and the limitations inherent in their archival regimes (see Table 1).

3.1 The National Archives of India

The NAI preserves literary memory primarily through archival initiatives grounded in state records management. These follow a documentary first approach. Its mission emphasizes the preservation and accessibility of India's cultural heritage through scientific archival practices, conservation technologies and professional records administration (National Archives of India, n.d.). Operating under the Public Records Act, 1993 and the Public Records Rules, 1997, the institution manages records across their lifecycle through appraisal, retention, transfer and preservation procedures. Records of permanent value are generally retained by their creating departments for 25 years before being transferred to the National

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

Table 1. Forms of memory production at Indian Archives

Institution	Archival regime/ infrastructure	Primary materials preserved	Form of literary memory produced	Digital infrastructure / approach	Key limitations or selectivities
National Archives of India (NAI)	Documentary archival regime grounded in state records management and legal frameworks	Manuscripts, correspondence, official files, private papers	Literature as documentary record and historical evidence	Digitization through high-resolution scanning, TIFF masters, checksum verification; Abhilekh Patal portal	Prioritizes documentary material; oral, performative and born-digital literary forms remain less visible
Sahitya Akademi	Canonical regime shaped by institutional recognition and literary authority	Manuscripts, published works, author archives, audiovisual recordings, oral archives	Literature as canonical heritage and nationally recognized literary tradition	Multimedia preservation including text, audio and documentary film	Canon formation privileges published authors and established literary traditions
Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL)	Linguistic preservation regime focused on documenting language diversity	Linguistic recordings, oral narratives, lexical documentation, field recordings	Literature as linguistic and cultural substrate supporting literary traditions	Digital language archives and linguistic documentation platforms	Ethical concerns regarding access, reuse and representation of community knowledge
National Digital Library of India (NDLI)	Database-driven discovery infrastructure aggregating institutional resources	Digital texts, educational resources, metadata records from partner institutions	Literature as searchable metadata object within large digital collections	Metadata normalization, federated search systems, rights-management frameworks	Discoverability depends on metadata quality and institutional participation
Archives and Research Centre for Ethnomusicology (ARCE)	Audiovisual archival regime focused on performance and oral traditions	Oral epics, ritual songs, storytelling traditions, ethnographic recordings	Literature as audiovisual performance trace	Audiovisual digitization and preservation of recordings	Recording transforms live performance into documentary form
Kalasampada (IGNCA)	Intermedial digital archive integrating multiple cultural media	Manuscripts, images, audiovisual materials, textual documentation	Literature as intermedial cultural assemblage	Multimedia digital platform with interoperable metadata and multilingual search	Access restrictions due to copyright and cultural sensitivity

Archives and no record older than 25 years may be destroyed without formal appraisal (National Archives of India, n.d.).

These procedures establish the epistemic conditions under which the past becomes state-recognized and publicly legible. Şerban's concept of law as mnemonic infrastructure is especially useful here, as it highlights how legal frameworks influence the categorization and preservation of historical materials (Şerban, 2024). In the case of NAI, literary materials enter the archive only when they become documentary objects such as manuscripts, correspondence, official files or private papers. Literature is therefore preserved not in the fullness of its cultural circulation but in what may be described as its documentary remainder.

Interview evidence supports this interpretation. As one NAI representative noted that they *focus on historical documents and would store in public domain the texts that can be physically seen on the portal.* The statement suggests that archival value is closely tied to material visibility and documentary authenticity. Literature becomes archivable only when it can be stabilized, authenticated and incorporated into the state's documentary order.

Digitization extends rather than transforms this documentary logic. NAI's digital preservation framework emphasizes high-resolution scanning, 24-bit color capture, uncompressed TIFF master files and checksum verification to maintain authenticity and long-term preservation (National Archives of India, n.d.). The Abhilekh Patal portal, launched in 2015, provides public access to digitized materials. While this digital infrastructure increases accessibility, it does not fundamentally expand the threshold of what qualifies as literary memory. Materials become digitally available only after passing through the same processes of appraisal, authentication and documentary validation.

Consequently, the archive remains oriented toward evidentiary stability rather than toward the dynamic and participatory forms of literary memory increasingly visible in digital culture. Literature appears primarily as documentary evidence rather than as living cultural practice transmitted through performance, oral traditions or digital circulation.

3.2 Sahitya Akademi

If the NAI operates through a documentary regime, Sahitya Akademi operates through a canonical texts first approach while archiving literary memory. As India's National Academy of Letters, the institution is explicitly dedicated to the development of Indian letters, the maintenance of high literary standards and the promotion of cultural unity through literature (Sahitya Akademi, n.d.). Its activities position it not merely as an archive of literary materials but as an institution that actively produces the symbolic category of Indian literature.

This institutional role can be understood through Edy and Austin's distinction between the archive and the canon. While archives preserve extensive collections of cultural material, the canon consists of those works that are publicly remembered and granted cultural authority within collective memory (Edy and Austin, 2022). Sahitya Akademi's initiatives such as the Archives of Indian Literature Project, documentary films on prominent writers, manuscript preservation programs and multilingual literary collections operate at this referential point of intersection. They transform a wide array of literary production into curated heritage representing the national literary tradition.

Importantly, the Akademi's archival practices extend literary memory beyond printed texts. Literary heritage is preserved through manuscripts, books, author portraits, audiovisual recordings, oral archives and documentary films. This multimedia approach reflects what Mandolessi describes as mnemonic assemblages, in which memory is distributed across multiple media forms rather than confined to discrete textual artifacts (Mandolessi, 2023).

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

Literature thus survives not only as text but also as voice, image, performance and institutional narrative.

Nevertheless, this process introduces important tensions. By emphasizing eminent writers and representative works, the Akademi privileges monumental and canonical memory over vernacular, experimental or born-digital literary forms. Interview evidence reflects this orientation. A representative from the Haryana Sahitya Akademi remarked that *if authors wished to preserve their work, they would publish it rather than leave it in electronic form*. The statement reveals a residual print ontology of literary value in which publication remains the primary marker of preservability.

In this respect, Sahitya Akademi illustrates the coexistence of traditional literary authority and emerging digital memory practices. While digital technologies expand the media through which literature can be preserved, institutional canonization continues to privilege established literary forms and print-based traditions.

3.3 The Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL)

The CIIL occupies a distinctive position in the landscape of literary memory because it preserves the linguistic foundations of literary expression. Its mandate includes promoting the development of Indian languages, supporting language pedagogy, protecting minority and tribal languages and documenting linguistic diversity through interdisciplinary research (Central Institute of Indian Languages, n.d.).

CIIL's archival initiatives include the Bhasha Sanchika language archive, the Scheme for Protection and Preservation of Endangered Languages, the National Tape Archive and digital repositories containing textual, audio, visual and ethnographic materials. These programs document more than 100 languages through field recordings, oral narratives, dictionaries and linguistic documentation.

From a literary perspective, CIIL preserves the conditions under which literature becomes possible. When languages disappear, so do the metaphors, narrative structures, songs, epics and storytelling traditions embedded within them. Literature in multilingual India often survives through oral performance, recitation and song rather than through printed texts alone. CIIL's multimodal archives therefore extend literary preservation beyond text-centered models.

This perspective aligns with broader scholarship emphasizing the role of community and personal archives in digital memory. As Zhao, Wu and Li note, personal and community-based digital archives increasingly contribute to collective memory and their value is determined both by individual significance and by broader social relevance (Zhao *et al.*, 2024). CIIL's collections similarly demonstrate how small-scale linguistic recordings and community documentation can carry immense cultural value even when they lack the scale or standardization associated with large digital data sets.

At the same time, CIIL's work highlights ethical challenges in the digital era. Once digitized, linguistic and cultural materials may become accessible within wider technological infrastructures that enable potential reuse or extraction. Interview respondents also emphasized that archival documentation must therefore balance openness with responsibility, especially when dealing with indigenous cultural materials.

3.4 The National Digital Library of India (NDLI)

The NDLI represents a different type of archival infrastructure. Rather than functioning primarily as a custodial archive, NDLI operates as a database-driven retrieval environment connecting millions of digital resources across institutions. Developed by IIT Kharagpur under the National Mission on Education through Information and Communication

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

Technology, NDLI aggregates more than fifty-five million resources in multiple languages from hundreds of partner institutions.

Its significance lies in the transformation of literary access. NDLI reorganizes cultural memory through metadata normalization, federated search systems and standardized rights frameworks. Literary materials become visible through searchable metadata fields and classification schemas rather than through traditional catalogues.

This model reflects Mandolessi's argument that contemporary collective memory increasingly shifts from narrative forms toward database structures (Mandolessi, 2023). Instead of encountering literature through curated historical narratives, users navigate collections through search algorithms, metadata filters and digital interfaces.

NDLI therefore resembles the schema of probability archiving. It does not guarantee comprehensive literary preservation but provides an expansive digital environment in which discoverability depends on indexing structures, metadata quality and platform design. Literary memory becomes tied to what is searchable and interoperable within the database system.

3.5 The Archives and Research Centre for Ethnomusicology (ARCE)

The Archives and Research Center for Ethnomusicology (ARCE) expands the concept of literary memory by foregrounding oral traditions and performance. Its collections include thousands of hours of recordings documenting Indian music, oral epics, ritual songs and storytelling traditions.

These materials demonstrate that literature in many cultural contexts exists not solely as written text but as embodied performance transmitted through voice, rhythm and communal participation. ARCE therefore preserves aspects of literary culture that cannot be fully captured within documentary archives.

Audiovisual records also introduce greater interpretive openness. As Ibrus and Ojamaa note, the semiotic richness of audiovisual media can undermine tightly controlled historical narratives because meaning emerges through sound, gesture and performance rather than through fixed textual interpretation (Ibrus and Ojamaa, 2020).

Yet recording performance also introduces a paradox. While digitization enables long-term preservation of ephemeral cultural forms, it simultaneously detaches them from their original social contexts. The act of archiving transforms performance into document, preserving its trace while inevitably altering its meaning.

3.6 Kalasampada and the intermedial assemblage of literary-cultural memory

Kalasampada, developed by the Indira Gandhi National Center for the Arts, exemplifies the archive as intermedial cultural assemblage. The platform integrates manuscripts, images, audiovisual recordings and textual documentation within a multimedia digital environment. Through interoperable metadata and multilingual search systems, Kalasampada allows users to navigate across multiple layers of cultural information rather than following a single linear narrative. Literary memory becomes embedded within wider networks of visual culture, historical documentation and performance traditions.

This architecture corresponds closely to Mandolessi's concept of mnemonic assemblages. Memory is distributed across artifacts, interfaces and digital relations rather than residing in isolated textual objects. At the same time, the platform illustrates how digital archives remain shaped by institutional controls. Because many materials are rights-sensitive, full access is restricted to internal networks, demonstrating that digital abundance does not automatically produce unrestricted accessibility.

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

4. Conclusion

The findings demonstrate that literary memory in contemporary India is preserved through multiple archival regimes rather than through a single institutional model. The NAI operates through a documentary regime grounded in state records management. Sahitya Akademi constructs canonical literary heritage through institutional selection and cultural consecration. CIIL preserves linguistic and oral traditions that sustain literary expression. NDLI reorganizes literary access through database infrastructures and metadata-driven retrieval. ARCE captures the performative dimensions of literary culture through audiovisual documentation, while Kalasampada illustrates the archive as intermedial cultural assemblage.

These institutions operate within a broader transformation in memory culture. Digital technologies do not simply modernize archives; they redistribute authority across institutions, platforms and users. Metadata standards, legal frameworks, interface design and digital infrastructures increasingly shape how literature becomes visible and retrievable.

The mission statements and archival practices of these institutions suggest that Indian digital archiving has so far focused primarily on digitized cultural heritage that included manuscripts, documents, recordings and other historical artifacts converted into digital form. Born-digital literary production and participatory digital memory practices remain only partially integrated into institutional preservation frameworks.

The key implication for literary studies is therefore that archives do not merely safeguard literature. They determine the forms in which literature continues to exist. Through their infrastructures and policies, they shape whether literature appears as manuscript, oral recording, metadata object, audiovisual performance or multimedia cultural assemblage. In doing so, they participate in the ongoing redefinition of literature under conditions of digitization, mediation and institutional selection.

References

Bar-Gil, O. (2025), "Holocaust remembrance in the digital age: the transformative influence of technology, digital archives, and connective memory", *Memory Studies*, Vol. 18 No. 6, pp. 1279-1301, doi: 10.1177/17506980241312341.

Black, A. (2024), "Memory and amnesia in the archival practices of national library and information associations", *IFLA Journal*, Vol. 50 No. 4, pp. 696-705, doi: 10.1177/03400352241236733.

Edy, J.A and Austin, J.T. (2022), "Generating more inclusive media memory: the limits and possibilities of news archives", *Media, Culture and Society*, Vol. 44 No. 4, pp. 802-819, doi: 10.1177/01634437211065700.

Herremans, B. (2026), "Resisting erasure: Palestinian literature and informal archives", *Memory Studies*, Vol. 19 No. 1, pp. 97-114, doi: 10.1177/17506980251397895.

Ibrus, I and Ojamaa, M. (2020), "The creativity of digital (audiovisual) archives: a dialogue between media archaeology and cultural semiotics", *Theory, Culture and Society*, Vol. 37 No. 3, pp. 49-70, doi: 10.1177/0263276419871646.

Şerban, M. (2024), "Law as mnemonic infrastructure: archival legal discourses and memory battles in Romania", *Law, Culture and the Humanities*, pp.1-24.

Verschure, P.F.M.J and Wierenga, S. (2022), "Future memory: a digital humanities approach for the preservation and presentation of the history of the holocaust and nazi crimes", *Holocaust Studies*, Vol. 28 No. 3, pp. 331-357.

Zhao, Y., Wu, X. and Li, S. (2024), "Perceived values to personal digital archives and their relationship to archiving behaviours: an exploratory research based on grounded theory", *Journal of Librarianship and Information Science*, Vol. 56 No. 3, pp. 677-697.

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026

Further reading

Asif, H. (2025), "Discostan and Hamnawa: between erasure and preservation in South Asian digital diasporic archives", *Media, Culture and Society*, Vol. 47 No. 8, pp. 1599-1618.

Briceño-Florez, E and Eccles, K. (2022), "Museums as platforms of resistance: the use of technology in conflict memory, transitional justice and peacebuilding", *Museum International*, Vol. 74 Nos 3-4, pp. 82-93.

Ensslin, A and Roy, S.B. (2023), "Electronic literatures as postcomparative media", *CompLit: Journal of European Literature, Arts and Society*, Vol. 5 No. 1, pp. 145-171, doi: 10.48611/isbn.978-2-406-14861-6.p.0145.

Hutmacher, F., Appel, M. and Schwan, S. (2024), "Understanding autobiographical memory in the digital age: the AMEDIA-Model", *Psychological Inquiry*, Vol. 35 No. 2, pp. 83-105.

Keating, T.P. and Storm, A. (2023), "Nuclear memory: archival, aesthetic, speculative", *Progress in Environmental Geography*, Vol. 2 Nos 1-2, pp. 97-117.

Kováčik, J. (2018), "The national project digital library and digital archives", *Alexandria: The Journal of National and International Library and Information Issues*, Vol. 27 No. 3, pp. 163-174.

Li, M and Wagner, C. (2026), "Choosing technology based on the memory of experiences: an empirical study of generative AI adoption", *International Journal of Human–Computer Interaction*, Vol. 42 No. 6, pp. 4193-4212, doi: 10.1080/10447318.2025.2537786.

McDonald, D. (2024), "Local Australian memory activism and the fast and slow violence of institutional abuse", *International Journal of Heritage Studies*, Vol. 30 No. 11, pp. 1350-1364.

Murphy, G and Greene, C.M. (2024), "A functional approach to memory 'errors' (and why technology need not doom Us all)", *Psychological Inquiry*, Vol. 35 No. 2, pp. 131-133.

Mutsagondo, S. and Chaterera, F. (2014), "Mirroring the national archives of Zimbabwe act in the context of electronic records", *Information Development*, Vol. 30 No. 3, pp. 254-259.

Redwood, H.A. (2020), "Archiving (In)justice: building archives and imagining community", *Millennium: Journal of International Studies*, Vol. 48 No. 3, pp. 271-296.

Roy, S.B. (2025), "e-sahitya, or the contested emergence of the electronic within the literary in India", *New Review of Hypermedia and Multimedia*, doi: 10.1080/13614568.2025.2453677.

Schellnack-Kelly, I and Modiba, M. (2025), "Developing smart archives in society 5.0: leveraging artificial intelligence for managing audiovisual archives in Africa", *Information Development*, Vol. 41 No. 3, pp. 626-641.

Simonetto, P and Butierrez, M. (2023), "The archival riot: Travesti/trans* audiovisual memory politics in Twenty-First-Century Argentina", *Memory Studies*, Vol. 16 No. 2, pp. 280-295.

Yeung, R.C., Stastna, M. and Fernandes, M.A. (2022), "Understanding autobiographical memory content using computational text analysis", *Memory*, Vol. 30 No. 10, pp. 1267-1287.

Corresponding author
Sushila Shekhawat can be contacted at: sula@pilani.bits-pilani.ac.in

For instructions on how to order reprints of this article, please visit our website:
www.emeraldgrouppublishing.com/licensing/reprints.htm
Or contact us for further details: **permissions@emeraldinsight.com**

Downloaded from www.emerald.com/dlp/article-pdf/doi/10.1108/DLP-04-2026-0163/11702537/dlp-04-2026-0163en.pdf by Diponegoro University user on 10 November 2026